

Primary Source Reading 2: Glaucon's Challenge

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Republic, Book II, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 12b: Glaucon's Challenge

Before you read: Socrates has just silenced Thrasymachus. Glaucon is not satisfied. He wants Socrates to prove that justice is worth having for its own sake — so he sets out to make the strongest possible case *against* justice himself, not because he believes it, but because he wants a real answer. As you read, notice the shepherd Gyges, and then the two lives Glaucon asks Socrates to compare.

Three Kinds of Good

GLAUCON: How would you arrange goods — are there not some which we welcome for their own sakes, and independently of their consequences, as, for example, harmless pleasures and enjoyments, which delight us at the time, although nothing follows from them?

SOCRATES: I agree in thinking that there is such a class.

GLAUCON: Is there not also a second class of goods, such as knowledge, sight, health, which are desirable not only in themselves, but also for their results?

SOCRATES: Certainly.

GLAUCON: And would you not recognize a third class, such as gymnastic, and the care of the sick, and the physician's art... these do us good but we regard them as disagreeable; and no one would choose them for their own sakes, but only for the sake of some reward or result which flows from them?

SOCRATES: There is this third class also. But why do you ask?

GLAUCON: Because I want to know in which of the three classes you would place justice?

SOCRATES: In the highest class, I replied — among those goods which he who would be happy desires both for their own sake and for the sake of their results. (357b–358a)

The Ring of Gyges

GLAUCON: According to the tradition, Gyges was a shepherd in the service of the king of Lydia; there was a great storm, and an earthquake made an opening in the earth at the place where he was feeding his flock. Amazed at the sight, he descended into the opening, where, among other marvels, he beheld a hollow brazen horse, having doors, at which he stooping and looking in saw a dead body of stature, as appeared to him, more than human, and having nothing on but a gold ring; this he took from the finger of the dead and reascended.

Now the shepherds met together, according to custom, that they might send their monthly report about the flocks to the king; into their assembly he came having the ring on his finger, and as he was sitting among them he chanced to turn the collet of the ring inside his hand, when instantly he became invisible to the rest of the company and they began to speak of him as if he were no longer present. He was astonished at this, and again touching the ring he turned the collet outwards and reappeared... Whereupon he contrived to be chosen one of the messengers who were sent to the court; whereas soon as he arrived he seduced the queen, and with her help conspired against the king and slew him, and took the kingdom. (359c–e)

What the Ring Would Prove

GLAUCON: Suppose now that there were two such magic rings, and the just put on one of them and the unjust the other; no man can be imagined to be of such an iron nature that he would stand fast in justice. No man would keep his hands off what was not his own when he could safely take what he liked out of the market, or go into houses and lie with any one at his pleasure, or kill or release from prison whom he would, and in all respects be like a God among men. Then the actions of the just would be as the actions of the unjust; they would both come at last to the same point. And this we may truly affirm to be a great proof that a man is just, not willingly or because he thinks that justice is any good to him individually, but of necessity, for wherever any one thinks that he can safely be unjust, there he is unjust. (360b–c)

The Two Lives

GLAUCON: Let the unjust make his unjust attempts in the right way, and lie hidden if he means to be great in his injustice: for the highest reach of injustice is, to be deemed just when you are not... he must be one who can speak with effect, if any of his deeds come to light, and who can force his way where force is required by his courage and strength, and command of money and friends.

And at his side let us place the just man in his nobleness and simplicity, wishing, as Aeschylus says, to be and not to seem good. There must be no seeming, for if he seem to be just he will be honoured and rewarded, and then we shall not know whether he is just for the sake of justice or for the sake of honours and rewards; therefore, let him be clothed in justice only, and have no other covering; and he must be imagined in a state of life the opposite of the former. Let him be the best of men, and let him be thought the worst; then he will have been put to the proof... And let him continue thus to the hour of death; being just and seeming to be unjust. When both have reached the uttermost extreme, the one of justice and the other of injustice, let judgment be given which of them is the happier of the two. (361a–d)

After you read: Notice what Glaucon has done. He has not argued that injustice is good. He has constructed a controlled comparison — stripping away every reward and punishment that normally comes attached to justice and injustice — and asked what is left once reputation is removed from the equation entirely. If the just man, genuinely just but thought to be a criminal, is still better off than the unjust man who is thought to be virtuous, then justice must be good in itself, independent of what anyone thinks of us. If not, then justice is just a strategy

for managing other people's opinions. This is the question Socrates spends the rest of the *Republic* trying to answer.